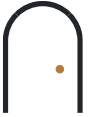


Before Anyone Moves In

Ten minutes of unglamorous questions prevents most of what would otherwise become a problem two months from now.



APPLICANT

SPACE

DATE

WHY THIS EXISTS

Almost every conflict traces back to an assumption nobody checked.

Not a fight — an assumption. One person assumed guests were fine. Another assumed the living room was communal. Neither was wrong. They just never asked. Someone who reacts badly to being asked has told you something valuable for free.

PART 1 — SCREENING QUESTIONS

Ask these in a normal, human way. This is a conversation, not an interrogation.

- ☐ What does your schedule usually look like?
- ☐ Do you cook much?
- ☐ What's your ideal living situation — social house, or mostly keep to yourself?
- ☐ Have you shared a place before? What worked and what didn't?
- ☐ What would make you want to move out?

That last one is the most underrated question on this page. People will tell you their dealbreakers if you ask directly. Also listen to *how* they talk about previous housemates — someone whose last three living situations were all ruined by other people is telling you something.

PART 2 — THE EXPECTATIONS CONVERSATION

Go through every one. Write the answers into the lease or a house agreement.

Guests

- ☐ How often is reasonable?
- ☐ How long can someone stay?
- ☐ Overnight — fine, occasionally, or a conversation each time?
- ☐ Advance notice expected?

Noise & schedule

- ☐ What time does the house get quiet?
 - ☐ Anyone on an unusual schedule — night shift, early mornings?
 - ☐ Calls and TV in common areas — any limits?
-

The living room and common space

- ☐ Genuinely communal, or primarily the owner's?
 - ☐ Can residents keep belongings there?
 - ☐ If it's primarily yours — **where else can people be?**
-

Undefined is what causes problems. Either answer is fine — **pick one and say it out loud.**

Kitchen

- ☐ Assigned fridge shelves, or shared?
 - ☐ Assigned cabinets?
 - ☐ Whose food is whose — separate, or some shared basics?
 - ☐ Dishes — how fast, and who's responsible for what?
 - ☐ Is there a second fridge, or should there be?
-

Laundry

- ☐ Where is it, and when is it available?
 - ☐ Schedule, or first-come?
 - ☐ Anything off-limits about the route to get there?
-

Cleaning

- ☐ Who cleans what, how often?
 - ☐ Is there a cleaner, and who pays?
 - ☐ What happens when someone doesn't do their part?
-

Parking

- ☐ Which spot is whose? Assign them. Write it down.
 - ☐ Guest parking — where?
-

Temperature

- ☐ Who controls the thermostat?
- ☐ Is there a range everyone can live with?

Genuinely one of the most common sources of low-grade tension in a shared house. Worth thirty seconds now.

Pets & smoking

- ☐ Policy on each — say it plainly

PART 3 — WHAT YOU'RE COMMITTING TO

Expectations run both directions. Tell them what they can count on.

- ☐ **Response time.** Urgent issues same day, everything else within a few days. Say a number, then meet it
- ☐ **How to reach you.** Text, email, an app — pick one channel
- ☐ **What's included.** Utilities, internet, cleaning, supplies — be specific
- ☐ **How rent is paid.** Platform, date, and that it's the same every month

Residents forgive things breaking. They don't forgive being ignored. Responsiveness is the single largest driver of whether people renew.

PART 4 — MOVE-IN DAY

- ☐ Written lease signed — **even for one room**
- ☐ Deposit collected and documented
- ☐ **Photos of the condition of everything** — same angles you'll use at move-out
- ☐ Keys handed over, and the lock was changed since the last resident
- ☐ Walk the house together — show them where things are, not just their room
- ☐ Assigned shelves, cabinets, and parking spot — physically labeled where possible

THE PRINCIPLE UNDERNEATH ALL OF THIS

Be rigorous about the systems. Be warm about the people.

The systems are what let you be warm later. When the rules are clear, written, and applied to everyone equally, you're never making a judgment call about a specific person — you're following the thing you both agreed to. That's what makes friendliness sustainable instead of exhausting.

Every door is an opportunity.

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